Metadata

Metadata plays a foundational role in shaping how digital collections are structured, accessed, and interpreted. As Steven J. Miller (2022) emphasises, descriptive metadata enables functionalities such as discovery, retrieval, and management, forming the backbone of any digital humanities (DH) project (pp. 29–30). Anne J. Gilliland (2016) believes that metadata accounts for content, structure, and context, stating that these three together enable digital objects to be meaningfully represented.

Miller (2022) explains that Dublin Core (DC) is a metadata schema developed in 1995 in Dublin, Ohio. It is a schema with a broad set of elements that are generic enough to apply to a wide range of projects (pp. 85-86). Through workshops organised by the Dublin Core Metadata Initiative (DCMI), DC's core strength lies in bringing together multilingual and international communities, allowing cultural institutions to exchange information (Caplan, 2003, p. 85).

Encoding

While metadata determines how digital objects are described and organised (Gilliland, 2016), encoding shapes how those objects are technically represented and interpreted (Berry et al., 2017). According to Berry et al. (2017), encoding is the process of making a message compatible with the technologies used to transmit it. For example, in telephone communication, a sound wave containing a simple sentence is converted into electronic signals that are sent over satellites and/or cables. In the DH, encoding is the process of making something readable whilst producing knowledge, with Text Encoding Initiative (TEI) encoding in some projects also used to interpret the material being worked with (pp. 65-68).

One available encoding scheme, XML, is defined by the Text Encoding Initiative Consortium (2024) as a device‑independent and system‑independent method for storing and processing texts in electronic form, making it a foundational component of TEI‑based encoding. The advantages of XML are: its emphasis on descriptive rather than procedural markup, its ability to distinguish between syntactic correctness and validity with respect to a document type definition, and its independence from any hardware or software system. Unlike HTML (which is commonly compared to), however, XML is extensible, its documents must be well-formed, and can be formally validated against a set of schema rules. It is also more interested in its data than in presenting it.

Enrichment

Lou Burnard (2014) remarks that the purpose of the Text Encoding Initiative (TEI) is to provide guidelines for the creation and management of digital data of all types used by researchers in the Humanities, including manuscripts. Not unlike XML (which it uses for its encoding), TEI has the following advantages: it cares about data, in particular text, it is independent of any software, and — last but not least — it was designed by the scholarly community specifically for the organisation of digitial data. TEI enriches items by making it possible to expand on a place location, for example, making it possible to link it to other annotations (Ciula et al., 2017, p.39).

Graffiti in Vienna

Although my catalogue does not use TEI, its usage would enrich the collection by marking features already present in the data, such as locations, graffiti types, or materials. Encoding these elements as structured TEI tags would allow items to be linked through shared places, motifs, or techniques, adding interpretive depth to the *Graffiti in Vienna* collection.

(500 words).

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